

MARK

THE

HOLY GOSPEL OF JESUS CHRIST,

ACCORDING TO S. MARK.

PREFACE.

S. Mark, who wrote this Gospel, is called by S. Augustine, the abridger of S.

Matthew; by S. Irenæus, the disciple and interpreter of S. Peter; and according to Origen and S. Jerom, he is the same Mark whom S. Peter calls his son.

Stilting, the Bollandist, (in the life of S. John Mark, T. vii. Sep. 27, p. 387, who was son of the sister of S. Barnabas) endeavours to prove that this was the same person as our evangelist; and this is the sentiment of S. Jerom, and some others: but the general opinion is that John, surnamed Mark, mentioned in Acts xii. was a different person. He was the disciple of S. Paul, and companion of S. Barnabas, and was with S. Paul at Antioch, when our evangelist was with S. Peter at Rome, or at Alexandria, as Eusebius, S. Jerom, Baronius, and others observe. Tirinus is of opinion that the evangelist was not one of the seventy-two disciples, because as S. Peter calls him his son, he was converted by S. Peter after the death of Christ. S. Epiphanius, however, assures us he was one of the seventy-two, and forsook Christ after hearing his discourse on the Eucharist, (John vi.) but was converted by S. Peter after Christ's resurrection, hæc. 51, c. v. p. 528. — The learned are generally of opinion, that the original was written in Greek, and not in Latin; for, though it was written at the request of the Romans, the Greek language was commonly understood amongst them; and the style itself sufficiently shews this to have been the case: —

Omnia Græcè;

Cum sit turpe magis nostris nescire Latinè. Juvenal, Satyr vi.

The old MS. in Latin, kept at Venice, and supposed by some to be the original, is shewn by Montfaucon and other antiquaries, to have been written in the sixth century, and contains the oldest copy extant of S. Jerom's version. — S.

Peter revised the work of S. Mark, approved of it, and authorized it to be read in the religious assemblies of the faithful; hence some, as we learn from Tertullian, attributed this gospel to S. Peter himself. S. Mark relates the same facts as S. Matthew, and often in the same words: but he adds several particular circumstances, and changes the order of the narration, in which he agrees with S. Luke and S. John. He narrates two histories not mentioned by S. Matthew; the widow's two mites, and Christ's appearing to the two disciples on the road to Emmaus; also some miraculous cures; (Mark i. 40, vii. 32, viii.

22, 26) and omits many things noticed by S. Matthew. . . But nothing proves clearly, as Dom. Ceillier and others suppose, that he made use of S. Matthew's gospel. In his narrative he is concise, and he writes with a most pleasing simplicity and elegance.

It is certain that S. Mark was sent by S. Peter into Egypt, and was by him appointed bishop of Alexandria, (which, after Rome, was accounted the second city of the world) as Eusebius, S. Epiphanius, S. Jerom, and others assure us. He remained here, governing that flourishing church with great prudence, zeal, and sanctity. He suffered martyrdom in the 14th year of the reign of Nero, in the year of Christ 68, and three years after the death of SS.

Peter and Paul, at Alexandria, on the 25th of April; having been seized the previous day, which was Sunday, at the altar, as he was offering to God the prayer of the oblation, or the mass.

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MARK 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. The beginning of the Gospel. The Greek word[1] and Latin derived from it, signifies the good news, or happy tidings about Christ's coming and doctrine. The word gospel is from the Saxon, God's spell, or good spell, i.e.

God's word, or good speech. Wi. — Some are of opinion that the termination of the first verse should be pointed with a simple comma, thus connecting it with the sequel; and the Greek text seems to favour this sentiment. According to the punctuation of the Vulgate, the first verse is merely the inscription or title.

Ver. 2. In Isaías, the prophet. That in the ancient copies was read Isaías, and not Malachy, is confirmed by the Syriac version, and also by S. Irenæus, Origen, S. Jerom, &c. It is also proved from an objection of Porphyrius, who says, S. Mark mistook Isaías for Malachy. In the ordinary Greek copies at present, we read in the prophets, not naming either Isaías or Malachy. The words seem taken partly out of one, and partly out of the other. These words, behold I send my angel before thy face, who shall prepare thy way before thee, are found Malac. iii. v. 1. And the following words, a voice of one crying in the desert: prepare ye the way of the Lord, make straight his paths, are in Isaías, c.

xl, v. 3. Wi. — In the beginning of his gospel, S. Mark alleges the authority of the prophets, that he might induce every one, both Jew and Gentile, to receive with willingness what he here relates, as the authority of the prophets so highly respected was very great. S. John is here styled an angel, on account of his angelic life, and extraordinary sanctity; but what is meant by, who shall prepare thy way, is, that S. John is to prepare the minds of the Jews, by his baptism and preaching, to receive their Messiah. Theophylactus. See in Mat. xi.

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Ver. 3. See Mat. iii. 3.

Ver. 4. For the remission of sins. Some commentators think from this that the baptism of John remitted sins, though he says in another place, I baptize you with water, but there has stood one amongst you, who will baptize you with water and the Holy Ghost, to shew that he did not baptize with the Holy Ghost, without which there is no remission of sin. This apparent difficulty will be easily reconciled, if we refer this expression to the word penance, and not baptism; so that by penance their sins were to be washed away, and there were baptized to shew their detestation of their former life. Jans. Concord.

Evang.

Ver. 6. See Matt. iii. 4. — Wild honey. Rabbanus thinks it was a kind of white and tender leaf, which, when rubbed in the hand, emitted a juice like honey.

Suidas thinks it was a kind of dew, collected from leaves of trees, and was called manna. But S. Chrys. Theophy. Euthy. and Isidore, with greatest probability, think it was honey collected by wild bees, in the fissures of rocks, or in the holes of decayed trees, which was insipid and unpleasant to the taste.

Tirinus.

Ver. 7. One mightier than I. The precursor does not yet openly declare our Lord to be the Son of God, but only one mightier than himself. The Jews were not prepared to receive his coming; he therefore wisely led them by degrees to the knowledge of what divine Providence had designed them; he yet secretly assures them that he is the Son of God. I have baptized you with water, but he shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost. Now it is evident that none but God can bestow upon man the grace of the Holy Ghost. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 9. See notes on our Saviour's baptism, Matt. iii. — That Christ was baptized by immersion, is clear from the text; for he who ascended out of the water must first have descended into it. And this method was of general use in the Church for 1300 years, as appears from the acts of councils and ancient rituals. It is imagined by some, that in the very spot of the river Jordan, where the ark stood whilst the Israelites passed over, our Lord (the ark of the covenant of grace) was baptized by S. John.

Ver. 10. Spirit. The epithet Holy is not found in most of the Greek MSS. but it is in John i. 32. and 33.

Ver. 11. The Greek printed copies, and some MSS. read with S. Matt. (iii. 17.) in whom, en o, ita. S. Chrys. Euthym. and Th. Some few, however, have en soi, in thee, with the Syriac and Latin text. P. — All the Fathers cite these verses for a proof of the Trinity: the testimony of the Father speaking, of the Son receiving the testimony, of the Holy Ghost descending in the shape of a dove. P. in Matt.

iii. 17.

Ver. 12. Into the desert. For the description of this desert, &c. read Maundrel's Travels, or extracts therefrom in Rutter's Evangelical Harmony. Vol. i. p. 169.

Ver. 13. The Greek does not express the forty nights, but we find it in S. Matt.

iv. 2.

Ver. 15. As if he were to say: To this day the Mosaic law has been in full force, but henceforth the evangelical law shall be preached; which law is not undeservedly compared to the kingdom of God. Theophy. — Repent, therefore, says our Saviour, and believe the gospel; for if you believe not, you shall not understand; repent, therefore, and believe. What advantage is it to believe with good works? the merit of good works will not bring us to faith, but faith is the beginning of good works. S. Jerom.

Ver. 16. We must observe that what S. Luke mentions, relative to the vocation of the apostles, is antecedent in point of time to what is here related by S.

Mark; since it is known that these disciples on some occasions returned to their fishing, until Jesus called them to be his constant attendants.

Theophylactus.

Ver. 24. The Greek text has here the same as in Luke iv. 34, Let us alone. V. — I know who thou art. It is a common opinion, that the devil did not know for certain that Jesus was the true Son of God. Yet S. Mark's words, both in this and v. 34, seem to signify he did know it. Wi.

Ver. 25. Christ would not suffer the devils to be produced as witnesses of his divinity; the author of truth could not bear the father of lies to bear testimony of him. Hence Jesus threatened him, in order to teach us never to believe or put our trust in demons, whatever they may foretell. S. Chrys.

Ver. 26. Tearing him: not that the devil tore the poor man's limbs or body; for S.

Luke (iv. 35.) expressly tells us, that the devil hurt him not. It means no more, than that he shook him with violent agitations. Wi.

Ver. 27. It is observed by S. Justin, (Apol. i. 54.) that the discourses of Jesus were short and concise. S. Chrys. (in hom. xlviii. in Matt.) says, that Christ here accommodated his preaching to his hearers, and to his subject. The ancients differ as to the length of time employed by Christ in the ministry of the word. It is most probable that he spent about three years in announcing to the world his heavenly doctrines. In the first year of his preaching, he seems not to have met with any great opposition; and on this account it may have been called, by the prophet Isaias, the acceptable year. Sandinus. — What is this new doctrine? In the Greek, This new manner of instructing. See below, xiv. 2, and xii. 38.

Ver. 30. It appears from S. Mark and S. Luke, that the cure of Peter's mother-in-law and the other sick, here mentioned, happened after the preceding narrative, and probably on the same day. But S. Matt. does not observe this order; for having related that Jesus, after the sermon on the mount, entered Capharnaum, and healed the centurion's

servant, he hence takes occasion to mention this and the other miracles, which he had omitted, and which Jesus had wrought at his first coming to Capharnaum. Rutter.

Ver. 34. The devils knew that it was Christ, who had been promised for so many ages before; for they saw him perform the wonders which the prophets had foretold of him; yet they were not perfectly acquainted with his divine nature, or otherwise they never would have persecuted to death and crucified the Lord of glory. S. Aug. — But Christ would not permit them to declare that they knew him. V. — See Luke iv. 41.

Ver. 44. It was not the intention of Christ, that he should not tell any body; had that been his wish, he would easily have realized it: he spoke thus purposely, to shew us that we ought not to seek the empty praises of men. He bade him also offer the sacrifices prescribed, because the law remained in full force till the passion of Christ, in which was offered a perfect sacrifice, that did away with all the legal sacrifices. Nic. de Lyra.

[1] V. 1. Euaggelion, Evangelium, bonum nuncium.

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MARK 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 2. Some Greek and Latin copies have, after eight days.

Ver. 4. Such diligence ought to be used to bring sinners to Christ, by means of the sacraments, as was used to procure for this man, through Christ, the health of his body. B.

Ver. 5. When Jesus saw their faith. Our Lord is moved to shew mercy to sinners, by the faith and desires, and prayers of others; for this man was not more helpless in his limbs, than in his soul. From this example, we are taught that in sickness the sacraments and helps of the Church, which are the medicines of the soul, should be called for in the first instance; for Christ first healed the sick man's soul, before he removed his bodily infirmity. We also learn that many diseases originate in sin, and that we are to remove the effect by removing the cause.

Ver. 10. The Son of man. Jesus Christ here proveth that himself as man, and not as God only, hath power to forgive sins; by this, that he was able to do miracles, and make the sick man suddenly rise; so the apostles and their successors, though they be not God, may in like manner have authority from God to remit sins, not as God, but as God's ministers, and acting in his name, and vested with his delegated authority. — On earth. This power which the Son of man hath to remit sins on earth, was never taken from him, but is perpetuated in his sacraments and ministers, by whom he still remitteth sins in the Church, and not in heaven only. Relative to sin, there is one court of conscience on earth, and another in heaven, and the judgment of heaven followeth and approveth this on earth; as is plain by the words of our Saviour, to Peter first, and then to all the apostles: Whatsoever thou shalt bind upon earth, it shall by bound also in heaven; and whatsoever thou shalt loose upon earth, it shall be loosed also in heaven. See Matt. xvi. 19. and xviii. 18.

Whereupon S. Jerom sayeth: that priests having the keys of the kingdom of heaven, judge in some manner before the day of judgment.

Ep. v. ad Heliod; and S. Chrys. more at large, l. iii. de Sacerd.

Ver. 12. This paralytic is not the same as that mentioned in S. John; for that distressed man had no one to assist him, whereas this person had four; the former was by the side of the Probatica, but the latter in a house at Capharnaum. Theophy.

Ver. 14. To follow Christ, is to imitate him; wherefore this apostle, that he might be able to follow Christ, the model of poverty, not so much by his bodily steps, as by the inward affections of his soul, forsook all; he not only forsook his present goods, but despised all danger, which he incurred by leaving his business abruptly, and without rendering any account of it to his employers or governors. Ven. Bede. — The person to whom Christ addresses the words, follow me, was Matthew: see infra ix. 9.

Ver. 17. The Greek printed copies, and some MSS. add to penance, as we read in Luke v. 33.

Ver. 18. See Matt. ix. 14, and Luke v. 33.

Ver. 20. Jesus Christ here foretelleth that fasting shall be used in his Church, no less than in the old law, or in the time of John the Baptist. See Matt. ix. 15.

— When first we begin to be converted to God, the spiritual consolations which God infuses into our souls, cause in us an overflowing of spiritual delights, so that we then feast, and are in the midst of delight; but when the Bridegroom shall be taken away, when these spiritual consolations cease, then we fast, and find the commandments difficult. It is then we must prepare ourselves for tribulation. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 25. When he had need. In necessity many things are done without sin, which in other circumstances it would be unlawful to do. B.

Ver. 26. Under Abiathar. The priest from whom David had these loaves, is called Achimelech, 1 K. xxi. The most probable answer to this

difficulty is, that the priest had both these names of Achimelech and of Abiathar, as also his father had before him. For he that (1 K. xxii.) is called Abiathar, the son of Achimelech, is called 2 K. viii. 17, Achimelech, the son of Abiathar. See also 1

Par. xviii. 16. Wi. — Others say that Abiathar, son of Achimelech, was present, and sanctioned the deed of his father, thus making it his own. Dion. Carth.

Ver. 28. The maker of the law may abrogate or dispense with it when and where, for just cause, it seemeth good to him: thus the Church can dispense with, change, or abrogate, for just reasons, the discipline of the Church founded upon Church authority. This we prove also from the action of David, (v. 26, supra) which the Scripture notices without blaming it, because the observance of the law, prescribed for the utility of man, must yield to the necessities of man.

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MARK 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. He entered again into the synagogue, viz. of Capharnaum. The man was there either, of course, on account of the sabbath, or to be cured by Jesus Christ.

Ver. 4. A difficulty here arises, how to reconcile S. Mark with S. Matthew. S.

Mark puts the words into the mouth of Jesus Christ: Is it lawful? When S.

Matthew says, that they interrogated him: Is it lawful? To cut the knot of this apparent difficulty, we must understand that they first put the question to our Lord, whether it was lawful to heal on the sabbath-day or not: and that Jesus understanding their secret thoughts, that they wished to have some grounds of accusation against him, placed the sick man in the midst of them, and said what S. Mark here relates of him: Is it lawful to do good on the sabbath-day, or to do evil? S. Aug.

Ver. 8. What is to be understood by Idumea, see Rutter's Evangelical Harmony.

Vol. i. p. 286.

Ver. 11-12. The unclean spirits being obliged by the Divine Power, not only to come and worship, but also to declare his majesty, exclaimed: Thou art the Son of God. How astonishing then is the blindness of the Arians, who even after his resurrection denied him to be the Son of God, whom the devils confessed as such when clothed with human nature. But it is certain that not only the devils, but the infirm that were healed, and the apostles themselves were forbidden, as well as the unclean spirits, to proclaim his divinity; lest the passion and death of Christ might be on that account deferred. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 13. He spent here the whole night in prayer, not that he who had all things to bestow, stood in need of prayer, or had any thing to ask; but to teach us that we must undertake nothing without previously recommending the affair to heaven, in humble and fervent prayer.

Ver. 14. The number twelve is mystical, as appeareth by choosing Mathias to full up the place of Judas: they are the twelve foundations, under Christ, of the heavenly Jerusalem. Apoc. xxi.

Ver. 15. He gave his apostles the power of curing maladies both of soul and body, and of expelling devils, that they might prove the truth of their doctrines by the authority of miracles. V.

Ver. 16. The evangelist here gives the names of the twelve. First, Simon, to whom he gave the name of Peter, in Greek, Petron, which signifies a rock; thus shewing that upon him his Church should be founded, as on a rock, never to be overturned. Tirin. — Polus, in his Synopsis Criticorum on this verse says that some Greek copies have, Proton Simona, First, Simon, which he believes to be the genuine reading: "nec dubito quin hæc sit germana lectio."

Ver. 17. And he called James, &c. The words, he called, are no addition, as they only express the literal sense: they are included in what is said, v. 13, that he called to him whom he would. — Boanerges, the sons of

thunder, or thunderers, is only to express their great zeal. Wi. — He gave also the two sons of Zebedee the name of Boanerges, (Boanerges) from the Syriac, Benairegesch; or the Hebrew, Beni, sons, regesch, thunder, noise or tumult. In conformity to their name, we find these two apostles asking Jesus, (Luke ix.

54.) wilt thou that we command fire to come down from heaven, to consume them? They spread the fame of the gospel through the whole world. So great was the zeal of S. James, that he incurred the resentment of king Agrippa, and was the first of the apostles to seal the doctrines of Jesus Christ with his blood. S. John also fulfilled the import of his name, as appears from his gospel, epistles, apocalypse, and the sufferings he underwent at Rome for the faith. SS. Peter, James, and John, were the only apostles to whom our Saviour gave particular names, a mark, perhaps, of his special affection for them. T.

Ver. 21. And when his friends had heard of it;[1] lit. his own. We cannot here understand his apostles, for they were in the house with him; but either some of his kindred and friends, or some that were of the same country and town of Nazareth, though perhaps enemies to him. — For they said. It is not certain who said this, whether his friends or his adversaries. — He is become mad.[2]

By the Greek, he is not himself. Christ might be called a madman by the Scribes and Pharisees, when he blamed their vices and when he preached with such extraordinary zeal. Or, as the Greek implies, he was thought to be transported out of his wits, and , as the Prot. translation hath it, was beside himself. If they were his friends that said this of him, they did not think so, but only pretended it, that they might get him safe out of the hands of his adversaries. Wi.

Ver. 22. From S. Matt. xii. 22. et dein. we learn that it was on the occasion of the delivery of a possessed person, this blasphemy was uttered.

Ver. 24. Kingdom against kingdom. As this is true in all kingdoms and states where civil dissensions obtaineth, so it is especially verified in heresies and heretics which have always divisions among themselves, as

a punishment for their abandoning the Church, the pillar and ground of truth, the only centre of peace and unity.

Ver. 29. See S. Matt. xii. 32. — Of an everlasting sin; i.e. of eternal punishment.

Wi. — What is here called everlasting offence, is (as S. Matt. expresseth it) that which shall neither be remitted in this life, nor in the life to come; which words would not be true, says S. Austin, if some sins were not forgiven in the world to come. Now, as no mortal sin can be forgiven after death, there must necessarily be smaller transgressions, which we call venial; though many of our separated brethren will needs have all sins to be mortal; which is very far from a comfortable tenet.

Ver. 32. The brethren of our Lord were not the children of the blessed Virgin: nor were they the sons of S. Joseph by a former wife, as some pretend; but in the Scripture language, and in this place, we understand by brethren the relatives of Mary and Joseph. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 33. Our Lord does not refuse to go out through any, the least, inattention to his mother; he wishes hereby, to teach us the preference we should give to the business of our heavenly Father, before that of our earthly parents. Neither does he consider his brethren as beneath his attention, but prefers spiritual before temporal duties; and shews us, that a religious union of hearts and feelings is far more lasting, and better rooted than any other ties of affinity or friendship whatsoever. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 34. The Pharisees were afraid lest the greatness of Christ's miracles, and the excellence of his doctrines, should put an end to their credit and authority among the people. Hence their calumnies against him.

[1] V. 21. Sui, oi par autou.

[2] Ibid. In furorem versus est, exeste; the word existasthai, is extra se esse, from which cometh the word ecstasy. See 2 Cor. v. 13, where S. Paul useth the same Greek word.

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MARK 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. If we examine S. Matthew on this point, we shall discover that this discourse was made on the same day as the preceding discourse; for S.

Matthew informs us, that having finished this exhortation, he the same day went and taught by the sea. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 10. When he was alone: in Greek *Ote egeneto Katamonas*; i.e. when he was retired and alone, either in the house, out of the city, or at a distance from the multitude. T.

Ver. 11. Such as are out of the Church, though they both hear and read, they cannot understand. Ven. Bede, in C. iv, Mark.

Ver. 12. That seeing they may see, &c. In punishment of their wilfully shutting their eyes, (Matt. xiii. 15.) God justly withdrew those lights and graces which otherwise he would have given them, for their effectual conversion. Ch. —

These speeches here and elsewhere, we are not to understand as if he spoke in parables to this end that the hearers might not understand, lest they should be converted; but we must learn the true sense from the corresponding texts in Matt. xiii, and Acts xxviii, where our Saviour and S. Paul render it thus: with their ears they have been dull of hearing, and their eyes they have shut. lest, perhaps, they may see, and understand, and be converted, and I heal them.

Whereby it is evident, that the speaking in parables was not the cause, (for many besides the apostles heard and understood) but themselves, who would not hear and understand, and be converted: and thus they were the real cause of their own wilful and obstinate infidelity. And therefore also he spoke in parables, because they were not worthy to understand, as the others were to whom he expounded them. B.

Ver. 22. All my parables, doctrines, and actions, which appear now to you so full of mystery, shall not always be so: in due time they shall all be publicly expounded by you, my apostles, and by your successors. Tirinus.

Ver. 23. And let him learn that he is not to bury in unjust silence the instructions or the examples I give him; but must exercise them for the light and direction of others. V.

Ver. 24. Pay attention then to what you hear this day, that you may retain it, and communicate it to others, your brethren; for as you measure to others, so shall it be meted unto you; yes, more shall be given to you, who receive the word of God, if you be attentive to preserve it yourselves, and to communicate it to your brethren. V.

Ver. 25. They who do not profit by the knowledge of the word of God, shall in punishment of their neglect, lose the advantage which they may seem to have, since it will turn in the end to their greater condemnation: and moreover, by trusting to their own judgment, they interpret the word in a perverse sense, and thus also lose what they seem to have. Nic. de Lyra. — Let those who talk so much about Scripture, and interpret it according to their own private spirit or fancy, see lest this also attach to them. A.

Ver. 26. So it is with him who announces the gospel of the kingdom of God, as with the sower. For whether he sleep or rise, the seed will grow up while he knoweth not; and the well prepared soil will, by the blessing of God, be productive: so the word of God shed abroad in the heart of man, will increase and fructify independently of all the preacher's solicitude, till he who has received it, being arrived at the measure of the age and fulness of Christ, shall be withdrawn by God from this world, and be called to himself. V.

Ver. 29. When the fruit is brought forth: lit. when the fruit[1] hath produced. By the fruit is here meant the seed; i.e. when the seed by degrees hath produced the blade, then the ear, and lastly the corn, which is become ripe. Wi. — This is a secondary sense of the text, when

the fruit hath come to maturity, and by no means a forced interpretation.

Ver. 33. This seems to contradict what was said v. 12, that seeing they may not see, &c.; but we must observe, that parables have more explanations than one, some more easy, whilst others are more difficult to be understood. In parables, the multitude understood the more literal interpretation, whilst Christ explains the more abstruse and hidden sense to his apostles. Hence there is no contradiction in these texts. Nic. de Lyra.

[1] V. 29. Cum produxerit fructus. In the Greek, fructus is in the nominative case; otan de parado o karpos, &c.

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MARK 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 2. Ven. Bede gives a beautiful explanation of this miracle. He says that it represents the Gentiles, who were converted to the faith by the apostles. The legion represents the innumerable vices to which they were subject, neither restrained by the laws of God nor man, but breaking through every restraint, and wallowing in all kinds of uncleanness. Ven. Bede. — The three evangelists agree in the expulsion of the legion of devils, except that S. Matt. makes mention of two demoniacs, and SS. Mark and Luke only of one. The difficulty is thus solved by S. Austin. S. Mark and S. Luke only mention one, as being more generally known, and particularly frightful in the neighbourhood. S. Aug.

Ver. 7. I adjure thee by God. The same is, I earnestly beg of thee not to torment me, by sending me into hell, and confining me in the abyss, there to be more tormented than I am at present. See S. Luke viii. 31. Wi.

Ver. 9. My name is Legion. Spirits have no names, only with respect to our language. These devils say their name is Legion, because they are many. Wi.

Ver. 13. Jesus Christ permitted the devil to destroy these swine, that from their destruction, the men of that country might take the alarm, and be converted.

Ven. Bede.

Ver. 17. Astonished at the miracle that had been performed, and displeased with the loss of their herds, they refused the Saviour of the world entrance into their country. Theophy. — It is observed that all Christ's miracles, except this, and the blasted fig-tree, were of the beneficent kind. We cannot but pity the wretched blindness of the Gerasens, in driving Jesus from their coasts. As a just judgment of God, their city was the first that fell into the hands of the Romans, in the fatal war under Vespasian.

Ver. 18. That he might be with him; i.e. as one of his disciples. S. Amb. says Christ did not grant his request, lest they might think that he sought to be glorified by men, in having always in his company a man out of whom he had cast so many devils. Christ himself seems to give us another reason, that the man might go, and publish in his own country the miracles done by Jesus. Wi.

Ver. 19. And he admitted him not: By Christ's conduct on this occasion, he teaches his disciples that they ought sometimes to make known their own good works, when either the glory of God or the edification of their neighbour were likely to be advanced by such a manifestation: otherwise they ought to conceal them, out of a spirit of humility. Dion. Carth.

Ver. 20. Decapolis, a territory on the eastern borders of the sea of Tiberias, and is so called, from ten principal towns that compose it. V.

Ver. 23. S. Matt. says: my daughter is even now dead. The sense in both is exactly the same. S. Matt. attended rather to the thoughts of Jairus, than to his words; for, as he left her dying, he could not reasonably hope to find her still in the same state; and, as he expected she was already dead, when he spoke this to Jesus, S. Matt. relates what the man thought at that instant, not what he said. S. Aug.

Ver. 28. Touch his garment. Almighty God is pleased to give occasionally to the relics and clothes of his pious and faithful servants, a degree of virtue. See Acts v, and xix, where the very shadow of S. Peter, and the handkerchiefs and aprons that had touched the body of S. Paul, and were brought to the sick, cured their diseases, and banished the wicked spirits. See S. Chrysostom, T. 5.

contra Gent. in vit. Babylœ. S. Basil saith: "he that toucheth the bone of a martyr, receiveth in some degree holiness of the grace or virtue that is therein.

Bas. in Psalm cxv.

Ver. 30. Virtue that hath proceeded from him. Virtue to heal this woman's malady proceeded from Christ, though she touched but his coat: so when the saints by their relics and garments perform miracles, the grace and force thereof cometh from our Saviour; they being but the means of instruments of the same. B.

Ver. 35. Ruler of the synagogue. His house is understood.

Ver. 36. Only believe. Dissenters grossly abuse this and other similar texts of Scripture, to prove that faith alone will suffice for justification; whereas God only declares, that he requires a faith in his almighty power for the performance of miracles, and that without this necessary predisposition, he will not do any miracles. See v. 5, of the following chapter.

Ver. 41. Only three resurrections from the dead are mentioned as performed by our Saviour: one just dead; one carried out to be buried; and Lazarus, already in his tomb. These represent the different states of sinners dead in sin, some more desperate than others. To such as have been for years in sin, and have none to intercede for them, we must apply the words of Christ, suffer the dead to bury the dead. Ven. Bede, and S. Aug. de verb. Dom. serm. 44.

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MARK 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 1. After the miracles that Christ had performed, though he was not ignorant how much they despised him, yet that there might be no excuse for their disbelief, he condescended to return to them.

Theophylactus.

Ver. 3. S. Matt. relates that they asked: Is not this the son of the carpenter? It is not improbable that both questions were asked; it was certainly very natural to take him for a carpenter, who was the son of one. S. Austin. — They were scandalized at his lowly birth and humble parentage. Hence Jesus Christ takes occasion to expose the malice and envy of the Jews, in refusing him, and to shew that the Gentiles would more esteem him. See Luke iv. 25, and John i.

Ver. 13. It was usual for the Jews to prescribe oil as a proper thing to anoint the sick; but its virtue in the present instance, when used by the apostles, was not natural but supernatural, and was derived from him who sent them; because this unction always produced a certain and constant cure in those who were anointed. This miraculous gift of healing the sick with oil, which Christ conferred on his apostles, was a prelude or gradual preparation to the dignity to which he raised this unction, when he established it a perpetual rite in his holy Church.

Rutter. — With oil, &c. This anointing the sick, was at least a figure of the sacrament, which Christ was pleased to institute for the spiritual relief of persons in danger of death: and which is fully expressed by S. James, in his Catholic Epistle. C. vi. The Council of Trent says this sacrament was insinuated in S. Mark, and published in the Epistle of S. James. Trid. sess. xiv.

c. 1. Wi.

Ver. 14. The Herod here mentioned was the son of Herod, from whom S.

Joseph fled with Jesus and Mary into Egypt. S. Chrys. hom. xlix. in Matt. —

How great was the envy of the Jews, is easily to be conceived from this passage. They can believe that John is risen from the dead, and appeared in public again, although no one gave testimony that this was the case: but that Jesus, so much favoured by God, who worked so many and so great miracles, should be risen again is incredible, although attested by angels, by apostles, by men, women, and persons of every denomination. They still assert that the body of Jesus was stolen. V. Bede.

Ver. 20. Herod,[2] &c. The sense both of the Latin and Greek text seems to be, that Herod entertained and shewed a particular respect and value for John the Baptist: yet some expound it, that he had a watchful eye over him, and sought only for an occasion to take him off. Wi.

Ver. 26. It is customary, in Scripture, to give the generally prevailing sentiment at the time; thus Joseph is called by the blessed Virgin, the father of Jesus; so now Herod is said to be stricken with sadness, because he appeared to be so to the company at table, though within his own breast, he secretly rejoiced that he had an opportunity of destroying an importuning monitor, with an exterior shew of piety and honour. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 29. Church history informs us, that the Christians were accustomed to frequent this tomb with great piety and respect, till the reign of Julian the apostate, at which time the pagans, through hatred for Christianity, broke open his tomb, and dispersed his bones; but immediately after, thinking it better to burn them, they endeavoured to collect them again. But some religious of a neighbouring convent,

joining themselves to the pagans, under pretence of collecting the bones to burn, secreted the greater part of them, and sent them to Philip, at Jerusalem, who sent them to Athanasius, bishop of Alexandria; and in the reign of Theodosius, the temple of Serapis was converted into a Christian church, and dedicated to the honour of S. John the Baptist, where his relics were deposited. Gloss. Ordina.

Ver. 37. For two hundred pence. See Matt. xviii. 28. The apostles seem to speak these words ironically, to signify that they had not so much money as could procure a mouthful for each of them. Wi.

Ver. 45. The apostles were in a desert place belonging to Bethsaida, which probably was divided from it by some bay or creek, that ran into the land; and Christ only ordered them to pass over this to the city, where he might afterwards have joined them, when he had sent away the people. But in their passage a great storm arose, and they were driven by an adverse wind to the open sea, towards Capharnaum; or, probably, when they found the wind so violent, afraid of shipwreck if they neared the shore, they rowed out to sea.

This reconciles the seeming discrepance of S. Mark and S. John, when notwithstanding the directions Christ had given his disciples to go before him to Bethsaida, we find them going to Capharnaum. Rutter.

Ver. 48. Thus the divine mercy often seems to desert the faithful in the height of tribulation, but God only acts thus, that he may try their patience, and reward them more abundantly. Nic. de Lyra.

Ver. 52. They understood not concerning the loaves;[3] i.e. they did not reflect how great a miracle that was which Christ had lately wrought, otherwise they would not have been so much surprised at his walking upon the sea. Wi.

[1] V. 5. Non posse in Scripture, is divers times the same as nolle. So Gen.

xxxvii, it is said of Joseph's brothers, they could not, (non poterant) i.e. would not, speak to him peaceably. See Jo. xii. 39, &c.

[2] V. 20. Custodiebat eum, suneterei auton. The Prot. translation, observed him.

[3] V. 52. Non intellexerunt de panibus, ou gar sunekan epi tois artois.

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MARK 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 2. With common hands. It may be translated, with defiled hands; as also v.

15; but the circumstances plainly shew the sense. Wi.

Ver. 3. Often washing, &c.[1] Some would have the Greek to signify unless they wash up to the elbows, but I think without sufficient grounds. Wi.

Ver. 4. Washed: lit. baptized. By beds are not understood night beds, but couches to eat upon, as it was then the custom. Wi.

Ver. 7. See the annotations Matt. xv. 9, 11. It is groundless to pretend from this text, that the precepts and traditions of the Church are not binding and obligatory, for Christ himself has commanded all to hear his Church, and obey their lawful pastors. These indeed may be called the precepts of men, but they are precepts of men invested with power and authority from God, and of whom Christ himself said, (Luke x. 16.) He that heareth you, heareth me; and he that despiseth you, despiseth me.

Ver. 9. Well do you. Christ here speaks by the figure called irony. Wi.

Ver. 17. Asked him the parable. Asked him to explain its meaning.

Ver. 24. If he desired to conceal himself, and could not, his will it seems was under control; but this is impossible. His will must always take place. On this occasion, therefore, he wished himself to be sought for by these Gentiles, but not to be made known by his own apostles.

Wherefore it came to pass, that not the persons who were his followers, but the Gentiles who entered the house in which he was, published his fame abroad. S. Augustine. — Jesus Christ commanded his disciples not to publish that he was come into that country; not that he intended to cease from healing the infirm, and curing diseases, when he saw the

faith of the inhabitants deserved it; for he informed the Gentile woman of his coming, and made it known to as many others as he thought worthy; but that he might teach us, by his example, to decline the applause of men. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 25. This part, in which S. Mark says that Christ was in the house, when the woman came to petition in behalf of her daughter, seems to differ from the narration of S. Matthew, who says that the disciples besought Christ to dismiss her, because she cried after them; by which he signifies, that she followed them as they were on the road. These apparent differences may thus easily be reconciled. The woman came to our Lord when he was in the house, and he, according to S. Matthew, not answering her a word, went out during the silence: the woman followed after, and by her perseverance obtained her request. S. Austin.

Ver. 32. Dumb.[2] The Greek signifies one that speaks little, or with difficulty.

Wi. — They besought him. In the Greek it is, they beseech him, which agrees so well with they bring, that we have every reason to believe that this was the original reading.

Ver. 34. Ephphetha, a Syriac word. Jesus Christ, in the cure of this man, uses many and various actions; but as of their own nature they are no ways equal to such a cure, they shew: first, that the cure was miraculous; and secondly, the virtue, which his divinity communicated to his sacred body. V. — We must not suppose that our Saviour here groaned on account of any difficulty he experienced in working this miracle, but only from commiseration for the man, whom he was about to heal; as likewise to shew, how very difficult is the cure of those who are spiritually deaf and dumb by sin. He was affected in a similar manner when he raised Lazarus to life, to shew with what difficulty a man, dead and buried in sin by evil habits, can arise from that miserable state. Dion.

Carth.

[1] V. 3. Crebo, ean me pugme. Mr. Bois, prebend of Ely, defends the Latin version, and says pugme comes from pukna and puknos. But Theophylactus would have it to signify, up to the elbows; achri tou agkonos.

[2] V. 32. Mutum, dumb; Greek, mogilalon, qui parum loquitur.

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MARK 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 8. After the multitude had eaten and were filled, they did not take the remains; but these the disciples collected, as in the former miracle of the multiplication of the loaves. By this circumstance we are taught to be content with what is sufficient, and to seek no unnecessary supplies. We may likewise learn from this stupendous miracle the providence of God and his goodness, who sends us not away fasting, but wishes all to be nourished and enriched with his grace. Theoph. — Thus does our Lord verify in his works what he has promised in his instructions; that if we will seek in the first instance the kingdom of God and his justice, that all necessary things shall be added unto us. By the gathering up of the fragments that remained, he not only made the miracle more striking to the multitude and to the apostles, but has also left us a practical lesson, how, in the midst of plenty, which proceeds from the munificence of heaven, we must suffer no waste. A.

Ver. 9. S. Mat. (xv. 38.) adds, without counting either the women or the children.

Ver. 10. Dalmanutha. S. Mat. (xv. 39.) has, to the borders of Magedan; in Greek, Magdala, or Magedan. These were two towns beyond the sea of Galilee, situated near to each other; it is of little consequence which of these names the Evangelists mention; perhaps our Saviour visited both. Tir. — The major part of commentators, if we can believe the Bible of Vence, take Magedan, or Magdala, to be the town of that name situated to the east of the lake of Tiberias, in the vicinity of Gerasa, and Dalmanutha to be the name of that part of the country in which these two towns were situated. V. — Polus in his *Synopsis Criticorum*, (vol. iv. p. 410.) gives three explanations for the discrepance of the names in SS. Matthew and Mark: 1. *Idem locus erat binominis*, the same place might have two names. 2. *Propiqua erant loca*, the places were near. 3. *Alterum erat regio, alterum vicus*, the one was the name of the territory, the other of the town or village; and concludes with asserting from Jewish authorities, that it was the same territory in which the two villages Magedan and Dalmanutha were

situated; so that it might be known by either name, as we find the territory of Gadara and of Gergesæ is one and the same.

Polus.

Ver. 11. Jesus Christ did not consent to the petition they made him, because there will be another time for signs and wonders, viz. his second coming, when the powers of heaven shall be moved, and the moon refuse her light.

This his first coming is not to terrify man, but to instruct and store his mind with lessons of humility, and every other virtue. Theophy.

Ver. 12. Jesus Christ fetches a deep sigh on account of their obduracy, and says; why do these ask for a miracle to confirm their belief, when they resist the authority of so many miracles, which are daily performed under their eyes?

V. — A sign shall not be given. But by a Hebrew form of speech, if divers times is put for a negative. Wi.

Ver. 15. Of the leaven of Herod. In S. Matt. c. xvi. v. 6, we read of the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees: we may conclude that Christ named all of them.

Wi.

Ver. 23. It may be asked, why our Lord led the man from the multitude before he cured him? — It may be answered, that he did it not to seem to perform his prodigies through vain glory; and thence to teach us to shun the empty praises of men: 2dly, to facilitate recollection, and to give himself to prayer, before he cured the blind man; and lastly, he went out of the city because the inhabitants of Bethsaida had already rendered themselves unworthy of the miracles of Christ. For among them our Saviour had wrought many miracles, yet they would not believe. S. Matt. xi. 21. Tir. Theophy. — Dionysius says, that Jesus led him from the multitude to shew that if a sinner, figured by the blind man, wishes to be converted from his evil ways, he must first leave all immediate occasions and inducements to sin. D. Diony.

Ver. 24. Men[1] as trees walking. In the Latin text, walking may agree either with men, or with trees, but the Greek shews that walking must be referred to men. Perhaps Christ restored sight in this manner to the man by degrees, to make him more sensible of the benefit; or to teach us how difficult is a sinner's conversion; of which this was a figure. Wi.

Ver. 25. Our Saviour made use of exterior signs in the performance of his miracles to command attention, and to signify the inward effects of the favours grants: these the Catholic Church, after the example of her Founder and Model, also uses in the celebration of her sacraments, and for the same purposes. Nor ought any supercilious and superficial reasoner to undervalue and condemn the corporal and external application of holy things, under the hollow plea, that we are exclusively to attend to the spirit and faith.

Ver. 28. As one of the prophets. In the Greek it is, one of the prophets.

Ver. 31. After our Redeemer had heard the confession of his first apostle, who spoke in the name of all, as the head, he opens out to them the grand mystery of his passion.

**[1] V. 24. Video homines velut arbores ambulantes, blepo tous
anthropous os dendra peripatountas.**

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MARK 9

CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 4. The law and the prophets were signified by Moses and Elias; both bear testimony to the divinity of Jesus Christ's mission, which was effectually to close the old, and open the new dispensation. By the apparitions of these two illustrious personages, we learn also that sometimes, though not often, there is, by the permission of heaven, a certain intercourse between the living and the dead. B.

Ver. 5. Peter had forgotten that the glorious kingdom of Christ was not of this world, but in heaven only; that himself and the other apostles, clothed as they were with their mortality, could not participate in immortal joys; and that the mansions in the house of the Father are not raised with human hands. He again shewed that he knew not what he said, by wishing to make three tabernacles, one for the law, one for the prophets, and one for the gospel, since these three cannot be separated from each other. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 9. Risen from the dead. The disciples believed the resurrection of the dead, but they knew not what Christ meant by his rising from the dead.

Their thoughts were filled with the idea of a glorious kingdom in this world, in which they should enjoy great dignities and offices under the Messias. Wi.

Ver. 10. The Jews here confound the two comings of Jesus Christ. The Baptist, in the spirit of Elias, will precede the first, and Elias in person, the second coming of Christ.

Ver. 14. The multitude were so solicitous to see Christ that they saluted him when yet a great way off. Some imagine that the countenance of our Saviour, being rendered more beautiful by his transfiguration, attracted the attention and admiration of the people. Theophy.

Ver. 20. Let those blush who pretend to affirm, that all men come into this world clear of original sin, and perfectly innocent like Adam when first created.

For why should this child be tormented by a cruel devil, if he had not been under the guilt of original sin, as it is clear, beyond dispute, that he could not be guilty of any actual transgression? Ven. Bede.

Ver. 22. The answer of our Lord is adapted to the petition of the child's father.

He had said: If thou canst do any thing, have mercy on us: and Christ answered: If thou canst believe, &c. Thus when the leper said: If thou wilt, thou canst make me clean, he answered: I will, be thou made clean. Ven Bede. —

[1]All things are possible to him that believeth. The sense is not, as if he that believeth could do all things; but that any thing might be done by the divine power and goodness, in favour of him that had a firm and lively faith. Wi.

Ver. 23. If the man believed, as he said, why does he add, help my unbelief? It may be answered: because faith is manifold; there is a faith of beginners, and a faith of the perfect. The incipient faith this man already possessed, and he besought our Saviour to help him to the higher degrees of this virtue. No one becomes great and perfect all at once, but must first set off with small beginnings, and thus gradually ascend to the height of perfection. Thus the man, who, by the inspiration of grace has received imperfect faith, may be said at the same time to believe, and still to be incredulous. Ven. Bede. — Here we are taught that our faith is weak, and has need of support and increase from God's assistance. When tears accompany our faith, they obtain for us the grant of our petitions. S. Jerom.

Ver. 26. Him whom the devil had made like to the dead, the goodness of Christ, by his charitable touch, restored to life. Thus proving at once both his divinity and humanity; the former by his wonderful cure of healing, and the latter by performing this cure by a touch of the hand.

Ven. Bede. — The devil could not inflict a real death on the child, on account of the dissent of the Author of life.

S. Chrys.

Ver. 27. This person, whom the apostles had forbidden to work miracles in the name of Christ, believed indeed in Christ, but did not follow him, on account of the great poverty of the apostles: he was not perfect, nor had he left all things to follow Christ. The apostles therefore concluded, that such a one was not worthy to work miracles in the name of their divine Master. But for this indiscretion, Christ rebukes them, saying , do not, &c. T.

Ver. 31. They could not comprehend what he said; and this not so much through the dulness and stupidity of their understandings, as through their personal affection to him; and because knowing him to be God, they could not conceive how a God could die. Nic. de Lyra.

Ver. 37. Who followeth not us, in that special manner, as Christ's apostles did.

Wi.

Ver. 40. Here we may find that no one, however poor, can be excused from good works; since there is no one who is not able to give at least a cup of cold water; and we are assured that he will not lose his reward. Nic. de Lyra.

Ver. 43. Where their worm dieth not. These words are taken out of Isaias lxvi.

24; and are to be expounded of the punishments, and fruitless repentance of the wicked in the next world. Wi.

Ver. 48. [2]For every one shall be salted with fire. The sense seems to be, that every wicked unrepenting sinner (of whom it was before said, that their worm dieth not) shall be severely and continually punished, though not consumed by the fire of hell. — And every victim shall be salted with salt; that is, even good men shall be cleansed and purified by trials and sufferings in this world, as some victims were to be salted by the law. Lev. ii. 13. Wi.

Ver. 49. Become unsavoury; i.e. if he, who has once received the faith, should apostatize from it, what is there that can possibly convert him from his wicked ways? since even the salt, with which he was salted, is become unsavoury, i.e.

the doctrines he formerly received are no longer of any use. Nic. de Lyra.

[1] V. 22. Omnia possibilia sunt credenti, dunata to pisteuont.

[2] V. 48. Omnis enim igne salietur, et omnis victima sale salietur, pas gar puri alisthesetai, kai pasa thusia ali alisthesetai.

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MARK 10

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 4. Moses permitted the injured husband to send away his wife, declaring that he had repudiated her. See Deut. xxiv. 1.

Ver. 5. Because of the hardness of their hearts, and to prevent the excesses they would otherwise have committed with regard to their wives. V.

Ver. 6. But from the beginning of the world it was not thus; for then God only formed one man and one woman, that they might be exclusively and invariably attached to each other.

Ver. 7. Hence it is written, (Gen. ii. 24, and Matt. xix. 5.) A man shall leave father and mother, and adhere to his wife.

Ver. 14. Unless we are possessed of the innocence and purity of little children, we cannot enter the kingdom of heaven. By the kingdom of heaven, we may here understand the truths of the gospel; for as a child never contradicts its teachers, nor opposes to them vain reasonings and empty words, but faithfully and readily receives their instructions, and with fear obeys them; so must we implicitly obey, and without any, the least, opposition, receive the word of the Lord. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 18. None is good. Of himself, entirely and essentially, but God alone: men may be good also, but only by a participation of God's goodness. Ch.

Ver. 20. We must recollect, that to the faithful observers of the Mosaic law, not only present goods were given, but the happiness of a future life promised.

Hence our Lord with reason inquired, whether he had kept the commandments. The innocent life of this young man is deserving of our imitation. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 21. Loved him. We need understand no more by this, than that Christ gave him some marks of his tenderness for him, and for all men by his kind instructions, and invitations to a good and perfect life. Wi. — It is worthy of inquiry, how that could happen which the evangelist here mentions, how Jesus could love this young man; when, as it is here related, he did not follow the admonitions given him by Jesus Christ. The reason is, Christ loved him for his past behaviour, and his strict observance of the old law. S. Chrys. in S. Thom.

Cat. aur.

Ver. 28. Although S. Peter had left but few things, he still calls them his all. For small things have power of attaching us to them, and of exciting our passions; therefore he that forsakes his small possessions, shall be a partaker of the blessings of Jesus Christ. Theophylactus.

Ver. 32. Christ goes before, to shew his eagerness to suffer the ignominies and torments of his approaching passion, for our salvation. Theophy. — But the disciples being already forewarned of what their Master was to suffer from the high priest and Scribes, went along the road to Jerusalem, with silent fear and trepidation, either lest they should be put to death with him, or lest he, whose life and doctrines they enjoyed, should fall into the hands of his enemies. But our kind Redeemer, foreseeing that the minds of his disciples were disturbed, comforts them with the assurance of his resurrection. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 35. S. Matt. (xx. 20.) says it was their mother, Salome, but probably at their solicitation, or at least with their connivance and consent.

Ver. 42. Who seem to rule over the Gentiles, &c. See Matt. xx. 25, and Luke xxii.

25. Wi.

Ver. 43. In vain then do men either seek for immoderate power, or sigh after human greatness; for, not power, but humility, is the sure and only path to the summit of perfection. He then proves to them by his own example, that if they would not believe his words, they might at least learn by his example. Ven.

Bede.

Ver. 46. Bartimæus is a Syriac word, and signifies, son of Timæus.

Ver. 51. Let us endeavour sedulously to imitate the good example of this blind man, who did not ask for honours, riches, or other worldly advantages, but only that he might receive his sight; that he might behold the light with the blessed angels, to which faith alone can conduct us. Ven. Bede. — In this worse than Cimmerian darkness, how few are found, who pray as they ought for this all-necessary light of faith!!!

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MARK 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 1. This place, doubtless, had its name from the great number of olive-trees that grow upon it. It lay a little out of Jerusalem, on the east side, about five furlongs from the city, according to Josephus; but he must be understood of the nearest part of it, since S. Luke makes the distance to be a sabbath-day's journey, i.e. eight furlongs, or a mile; unless we suppose he meant the summit of the hill, from which our Saviour ascended. Acts i. 12. Mr. Maundrell says: I and my companions going out of Jerusalem, at S. Stephen's gate and crossing the valley of Josaphat, began immediately to ascend the mountain; and being about two-thirds of the way up, we came to certain grottos, cut with intricate windings and caverns, under ground, which were called, the sepulchres of the prophets; that a little higher up, were twelve arched vaults under ground, standing side by side, and built in memory of the apostles, who are said to have compiled their creed in this spot. Sixty paces higher, we came to the place where Christ is said to have uttered his prophecy, concerning the final destruction of Jerusalem; and a little on the right hand, to another, where he is said to have dictated (a second time) the Lord's prayer to his disciples. A little higher, is the cave of a saint called Pelagia; a little lower, a pillar denoting the place where an angel gave the blessed Virgin three day's warning of her death; and, at the top of all, we saw the place of our blessed Lord's ascension. See Maundrell's Journey to Jerusalem. — In the Greek, being between Bethphage and Bethania. Bethania, which they had just left, was about one mile and a half from Jerusalem: Bethphage was between the two. V.

Ver. 2. This order of Jesus Christ shews his omniscience and supreme dominion. By the former, he informs his two disciples that in Bethphage they would find a colt tied; and by the latter, he assures them that the master, on learning that the Lord hath need of the colt, will immediately let him go. A.

Ver. 8. The martyrs strewed garments in the way by putting off the garments of the flesh, and thus preparing a way by their blood for the servants of God.

Many strew their garments in the way, by subduing their bodies in fasting and abstinence, and thus affording good example to those that follow them. Those cut down branches from the trees, who in their instructions take their seeds from the discourses of the Fathers, and, by an unassuming and humble delivery, spread them in the way of God. V. Bede. — Let us strew the way of life, and cut branches from the trees, by imitating the example of the saints.

For the saints are the trees, from which we cut down branches, when we imitate their virtues. Theophylactus. — The just shall flourish like the palm-tree, (Ps. xci.) confirmed in their roots, and extensive in their fruit and flowers, being the sweet odour of Christ. 2 Cor. ii. 15.

Ver. 9. They that went before, were the prophets; and they that come after, are the apostles. S. Jerom. — All these voluntary offerings were grateful to our divine Saviour; so are the like offerings made to him in the blessed sacrament.

B.

Ver. 10. They call the kingdom of Christ the kingdom of David, because Christ was descended of the family of David. David is likewise interpreted, strong of hand; but who is strong of hand but the Lord, whose hand has wrought so many and such miracles? Theophy. — How great is the similarity of this sentence with that delivered by the angel Gabriel, when he addressed the blessed Virgin Mary: "the Lord God will give to Him the seat of David, his father." Ven. Bede. — "In the highest." By this is meant, that the just shall be built upon the ruins of the angels; and, that the inhabitants of the earth shall obtain salvation. S. Jerom. — The literal meaning is: blessed be the kingdom of our father, David, which he sees arrive in the person of his Son: Hosanna, glory and salvation to this Son so long expected, so ardently desired: peace and salvation, and glory be given to Him, by the great Lord and God, who dwelleth in the highest heaven. S. Mat. xxi. 9. S. Luke xix. 38.

Ver. 11. In going into the temple, immediately on entering the city, he shews what religion recommends to us, viz. to enter first into a place of worship, if there is one, where we visit. Ven. Bede. — Looking into the hearts of all, he could not, amongst those who contradicted the truth, find where to recline his head; therefore, he withdraws to his faithful servants, and takes up his abode with the children of obedience. Idem.

Ver. 13. He came, if perhaps, &c. Christ knew there was no fruit upon it, and that it was not the season, or a season for figs. See Matt. xxi. 19, what instruction he designed to give his disciples by what he said and did to the fig-tree. Wi. — Jesus Christ here curses the barren tree, on account of his disciples, who were present; for as he every where gave instances of his most beneficent will, it was proper he should also give them proofs of his justice and severity. Hence his principal motive for cursing the fig-tree was, not on account of any hunger he then experienced; for it is not probable that Christ should experience so great hunger, and at so early an hour, as these words seem to indicate. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 16. The vessels here spoken of as not allowed to be carried through the temple, were not any belonging to the temple, but only such as were brought by those who were buying and selling. Origen asserts, that our Saviour's driving so many thousands out of the temple, poor and humble as he appeared, was a more astonishing miracle than even his giving sight to the blind. So divine an effulgency flashed from his eyes and whole countenance, as affected every beholder with astonishment and awful terror. Orig. in D.

Diony. — If Christ could not bear to see his Father's house profaned, even with those things which in another place were not unbecoming, how indignant must he be to see the temple of God defiled with blasphemous and heretical doctrines, and with that levity and inattention observed in thoughtless giddy Christians, who thus scandalize and pervert his devoted children. A.

Ver. 17. Not to the Jews only, but to all nations; not in Jerusalem only, but in every city of the known world. It is no longer a temple of bulls, goats, and rams, but a temple of prayer. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 18. What effect this strong reproof of our Saviour had upon the Jewish priests, and other ministers of the temple, is related by the evangelist in the subsequent words: they sought how they might destroy him. Still they were obliged to protract their iniquitous designs for a short time, as the multitude were in admiration of his doctrines.

Gloss. — It was on a Tuesday that Jesus Christ discussed various subjects in the temple, his mission, the duties we owe to society, the resurrection of the body, &c. &c.

Ver. 23. Ecclesiastical history informs us, that S. Gregory of Neo-Cæsarea, surnamed Thaumaturgus (whose feast is kept Nov. 17.) performed this miracle, removing by his prayers a mountain that obstructed the building of a church.

Ven. Bede.

Ver. 26. Faith alone will not suffice for the remission of sins; we must moreover pardon every neighbour, and from our heart.

Ver. 28. "It was a reasonable demand," says Dr. Barrow, "which was made to our Saviour: tell us by what authority thou doest these things, and who hath given thee this authority. The reasonableness of it our Lord did often avow, declaring, that if by his doctrine and works he had not vouched the divinity of his authority, it had been no sin to disbelieve or reject him." John v. 31, 36. x.

25, 37. and xv. 22, 24. Dr. Barrow on Supremacy, p. 49. — This principle, which supposes in pastors the necessity of a lawful mission, was formerly, and may still be, triumphantly urged against Luther, Calvin, Tindal, Cranmer, and all the first pretended Reformers of the Catholic Church. For whence, said the Catholics, did these innovators derive their mission? Who sent them to preach? Who gave them authority to reform and alter the whole state of God's Church? Let them shew their commission for this purpose, either ordinary or extraordinary. Unless they can do this, we have nothing to do with usurpers and intruders. . . . If it be pretended that they had extraordinary mission, immediately derived from God, why did they not shew their credentials, stamped with the broad seal of heaven; that is, why did they not by clear and evident miracles, such as Christ and his apostles wrought, attest their being thus extraordinarily commissioned for the extraordinary work of the Reformation? Without such proofs as these, no pretensions to an extraordinary mission, in opposition to the ordinary Church authority, can be admitted. Otherwise every fanatic or enthusiast, following his own caprice, may pretend to a call from heaven; and, upon this foolish plea, preach up his own dreams for the pure word of God, in contempt of all authority, whether of Church or State. If it be said that the missions of the first reformers were ordinary, and derived to them by the ministry of men, it behoves them to point out what men these were from whom they received this ordinary power. Were they Catholics or Protestants? Not

Protestants, for they cannot name any such who commissioned them to preach; not Catholics, because the religion which Luther and his reforming brethren endeavoured to propagate, was a new religion, directly opposite to that of Catholics, and therefore could not be taught, in virtue of any commission from Catholics. And how can they preach unless they be sent? Rom. x. 15. If it be urged that Luther had received his orders in the Catholic Church, it is easily answered that this could not authorize him to commence preacher and teacher of another religion, any more than the orders which Mr. Whiston and Mr. Wesley might receive in the Protestant church of England could authorize them to teach a doctrine anathematized by that Church. Rutter.

Ver. 33. Neither do I tell you, &c. I do not tell you what I know, because you refuse to own what you know. We should observe, there are here two reasons for concealing the truth from inquirers: 1st, when he that inquireth after the truth is incapable of understanding it; 2d, when on account of some contempt of the truth, or some other evil indisposition, the person is not deserving of having the truth laid open to him. Ven. Bede.

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MARK 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. Under these figurative modes of speech, or parables, Jesus Christ began to trace out for their reflection a true portraiture of their ingratitude, and of the divine vengeance. By this man we are to understand God the Father, whose vineyard was the house of Israel, which he guarded by angels; the place dug for the wine-vat is the law; the tower, the temple; and Moses, the prophets and the priests, whom the Jews afflicted and persecuted are the husbandmen or servants. S. Jerom. — This same parable was employed by Isaias, (v. 1.) where speaking of Christ, he says: My beloved had a vineyard, and he fenced it in. Tirinus. — He went into a far country, not by change of place, for he is every where, but by leaving the workmen the power of free-will, either to work or not to work; in the same manner as a man in a far country cannot oversee his husbandmen at home, but leaves them to themselves. Ven.

Bede. -- This parable is thus morally explained: Jesus Christ planted a Church with his own blood, surrounded it with evangelical doctrine, as with a hedge; dug a place for the wine-vat, by the abundance of spiritual graces which he has prepared for his Church; built a tower, by appointing his angels to guard each individual Christian, who are the husbandmen to whom he has let it out.

Nic. de Lyra.

Ver. 2. The first servant whom the Almighty sent, was Moses; but they sent him away empty; for, says the Psalmist, they provoked him to anger in the camp.

Ps. cv. The second servant sent was David, whom they used reproachfully, saying: What have we to do with David? 3 Kings xii. 16. The third was the school of the prophets; and which of the prophets did they not kill? Mat. xxiii.

Ven. Bede.

Ver. 7. From this it appears, that the chief priests and lawyers were not ignorant that Christ was the Messiah promised in the law and the prophets, but their knowledge was afterwards blinded by their envy: for otherwise, had they known him to be true God, they would never have crucified the Lord of glory, says S. Paul. For a further explanation, see S. Mat. xxi. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 8. They cast the heir, Jesus Christ, out of the vineyard, by leading him out of Jerusalem to be crucified. Theophy. — They had before cast him out by calling him a Samaritan and demoniac; (S. John, C. viii.) and again by refusing to receive him, and turning him over to the Gentiles. S. Jerom.

Ver. 9. The vineyard is given to others; as it is said, they shall come from the east and the west, from the north and the south, and sit down with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of God. S. Jerom.

Ver. 10. By this question, Christ shows that they were about to fulfil this prophecy, by casting him off, planning his death, and delivering him up to the Gentiles, by which he became the corner-stone, joining the two people of the Jews and Gentiles together, and forming out of them the one city and one temple of the faithful. Ven. Bede. — The Church is the corner, joining together Jews and Gentiles; the head of it is Christ. By the Lord hath this been done in our days, and it is wonderful in our eyes, seeing the prodigies which God has performed through him whom men reject as an impostor. Theophy. and V.

Ver. 12. The chief priests thus shew, that what our Saviour had just said was true, by thus seeking to lay their hands on him. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 14. The disciples of the Pharisees said this in order to induce our Saviour to answer them, "that they were not to pay tribute to Cæsar, being the people of God; an answer they confidently anticipated, and

which the Herodians hearing, might immediately apprehend him, and thus remove the odium from themselves to Herod. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 15. Knowing their hypocrisy.[1] The Latin word commonly signifies, cunning, but by the Greek is here meant their dissimulation, or hypocrisy. Wi.

Ver. 17. Although Christ clearly establishes here the strict obligation of paying to Cæsar what belongs to Cæsar, to the confusion of his very enemies, we shall still find them bringing forward against him the charge of disloyalty, as if he forbade tribute to be paid to Cæsar. Luke xxiii. 2. After the example of her divine Model, the Catholic Church has uniformly taught with S. Paul, the necessity of obeying the powers in being; and this not for fear of their wrath, but for conscience sake. Render to Cæsar the money on which his image is stamped, but render yourselves cheerfully to God; for the light of thy countenance, O Lord, is stamped upon us, (Ps. iv.) and not the image of Cæsar. S. Jerom. — With reason were they astonished at the wisdom of this answer, which eluded all their artifices, and taught them at the same time what they owed to their prince, and what they owed to God: and whoever hopes for the favour of heaven, must conscientiously observe this double duty to God and to the magistrate.

Ver. 26. The doctrine of the resurrection from the dead is clearly given in the book of Moses, where mention is made of the burning bush, from the midst of which God appeared to Moses: have you not read, I say, what God there said to him? As God is the God of the living, you must be in an egregious error in imagining, that such as die in the eyes of the world not to return thither any more, die in the same manner in the eyes of God, to live no more. V.

Ver. 29. Literally the Lord our God is the only Lord: and this is the sense of the text in Deuteronomy vi. 4. The word in the original text, rendered by the term Lord, is the grand name JEHOVA, which signifies properly God, considered as the supreme Being, or the author of all existence.

Ver. 33. Venerable Bede gathers from this answer of the Scribes, that it had been long disputed among the Scribes and Pharisees, which was the greatest commandment in the law; some preferring the acts of faith and love, because many of the fathers, before the law was instituted, were pleasing to God on account of their faith and piety, and not on account of their sacrifices; yet none were agreeable to God who had not faith and charity. This Scribe seems to have been of the opinion of those who preferred the love of God. Ven. Bede. —

This excellence of charity teacheth us that faith only is not sufficient. B.

Ver. 34. Being now refuted in their discourse, they no longer interrogate him, but deliver him up to the Roman power. Thus envy may be vanquished, but with great difficulty silenced. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 35. According to S. Mat. it was principally to the Pharisees that Christ proposed this question. See Mat. 22, 41.

Ver. 37. This interrogation of Jesus instructs us how to refute the adversaries of truth; for if any assert that Christ was but a simple and holy man, a mere descendant of the race of David, we will ask them, after the example of Jesus: If Christ be man only, and the Son of David, how does David, under the inspiration of the Holy Ghost, call him Lord? The Jews were not blamed for calling him the Son of David, but for denying him to be the Son of God. Ven.

Bede.

Ver. 43. God accepts alms, if they are corresponding to each one's abilities; and the more able a man is, the more must he bestow in charities. The widow's mite was very acceptable to God, and very meritorious to herself; because though small the offering considered in itself, it was great considering her extreme indigence.

Ver. 44. But she, of her want,[2] or indigence, out of what she wanted to subsist by, as appeareth by the Greek. Wi.

[1] V. 15. Versutiam. ten upokrisin.

[2] V. 44. De penuria sua, ek tes ustereseos. See the same Greek word, 1 Cor.

xvi. 17. 2 Cor. ix. 12, and C. xi. 9. &c.

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MARK 13

CHAPTER XIII.

Ver. 2. As Christ had frequently denounced the destruction of the temple, his disciples, surprised that so beautiful an edifice should be reduced to nothing, wish on that account to shew him the grandeur and magnificence of it; upon which Christ exclaimed: There shall not remain a stone upon a stone.

Theophy.

Ver. 4. When shall these things be? The miseries that took place previously to the destruction of the temple and city of Jerusalem, were a figure of the extreme calamity that will happen before the last day, in the reign of Antichrist: hence Jesus Christ speaketh indifferently of both. B.

Ver. 6. At the destruction of Jerusalem there appeared many impostors, many who professed themselves to be the Christ, and assured the populace that their delivery was at hand. And in the Church many heresiarchs started up, and many came in the name of Christ; the first of these was Simon Magus, mentioned in the Acts of the Apostles, whom the people of Samaria received as the power and virtue of God. But it is remarkable from the time of our Saviour's passion, when they preferred the robber Barabbas to Jesus Christ, the Lamb of God, they had no peace or quiet in the city, but constant tumult and dissension succeeded, to the very time of its destruction. Ven. Bede. — So shall many seducers come towards the end of the world, who shall make themselves authors of sects, and shall gain many disciples: as followeth in plain words, v. 22. of this chapter. B.

Ver. 9. In the synagogues, or assemblies. The word is here taken for assemblies of judges, and of justice. — For a testimony to them; i.e. that you may bear witness of me and my doctrine, and also against them. Wi. — Some solicitude perhaps had seized upon the minds of the disciples, when they were informed by their divine Master, that they should stand accused before kings, and princes of the earth, for fear they should not be able, for want of human learning, to make a proper defence. Our Saviour therefore says: be not thoughtful beforehand; for when we are brought to the bar in defence of our holy faith, it is only necessary for us, under such circumstances, to make an offer of our will; Christ himself will speak for us: and in our answers will be infused the grace of the Holy Ghost: for it is not you that speak, but the Holy Ghost. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 14. Ven. Bede here gives a beautiful illustration of this passage in a spiritual sense. When, says he, we see the abomination of desolation standing where it ought not, that is, when we behold heresies and crimes reigning where we ought to see truth and virtue flourish, then let those who are in Judea, such as have kept the true faith unpolluted, flee to the mountains; that is, rise to the height of perfection; and let those who are on the house-top, those who crucifying the works of the flesh, live according to the spirit, not descend any more to their former way of living according to the flesh. Ven.

Bede. — If all heresies tend to the abomination of desolation, that more particularly does which taketh away with other sacrament, and the external worship of God, the very sacrifice of Christ's body and blood; which being taken away, as S. Cyprian remarketh, no religion can remain. S. Cyprian on the supper of our Lord. Num. ii.

Ver. 19. Jospehus, the Jewish historian, relates the calamities that befell unhappy Jerusalem, about thirty-seven years after the death of Jesus Christ, which verified to the very letter the prediction: there shall be such tribulations as were not from the beginning. S. Austin.

Ver. 20. This may be explained in a more general sense of the persecution of Antichrist, which will be dreadful beyond description, and executed in every part of the world. The time however allowed to him and his wicked agents to tread under foot the holy city, (Apoc. xi. 2.) i.e. the Church of Christ, will not extend beyond forty-two months, or three years and a half. This space of time Christ has set apart to purify his Church, and try his servants; and therefore he allows them to fall under the power of this merciless tyrant; and it was given unto him, says S. John, speaking of this event, to make war with the saints, and overcome them. Apoc. xiii. 7. We are admonished of the same by the prophet Daniel: (vii. 21.) I beheld, says he, and lo that horn (Antichrist) made war against the saints, and prevailed against them; and he shall speak words against the Most High, and shall crush the saints of the Most High . . . and they shall be delivered into his hand until a time, and times, and half a time, (Dan.

vii. 25.) i.e. a year, two years, and half a year, or three years and a half, the same with S. John. Pastorini. p. 327 and 8. — S. Austin, speaking of this dreadful period, says: this persecution will be the last; it will happen towards the approach of the last judgment, and will fall upon the Church in every part of the world; that is, the whole city of Christ will be persecuted by the whole city of the devil, as far as both are extended upon earth. De civit. l. xx. c. xi. But our Saviour will put a stop to these calamities on account of his elect, unwilling that they should be tempted above their strength; for he will descend himself from heaven, and, as S. Paul tells us, will kill the wicked man, Antichrist, with the breath of his mouth, and shall destroy him with the brightness of his coming.

Ver. 24. In the day of judgment the luminaries of heaven shall be darkened, not by the privation of their light, but by the approach of the true light of the world, i.e. the great Judge. And what cause for wonder can there be, that man should be terrified at the thoughts of the last day, when the angelic powers shall tremble; or, how will these mortal habitations of ours stand the shock, when the very pillars of heaven shall be moved? what will the tender osier suffer, when the lofty cedars of Paradise bend their head! Ven. Bede.

Ver. 32. But how can the Son be ignorant of that last day? Were this the case, we must thence conclude that his nature was imperfect: since he was under the necessity of a second coming, and yet was ignorant when that time should be. But we must remember, that the meaning of this sentence is not, that Christ was really ignorant of this circumstance, but only that it was not then a convenient time to disclose the secret. S. Austin. — Not as if Christ were ignorant himself, as certain Eutychian heretics, called Agnoitæ, held; but because he knew it not as our teacher, to teach it others, as being not expedient. S. Ambrose de fide, l. v. c. viii. — The Son of God is ignorant of this day, not according to his divinity, which sees and knows all things; but according to his humanity, which does not know it of itself, of its own light, but by revelation which is made to it by the divinity, which is intimately united to it.

In naturâ quidem divinitatis novit, says S. Gregory, non ex naturâ humanitatis.

See S. Matt. xxiv. 36.

Ver. 33. Some will perhaps think, that it would have been much better, if the Almighty had not left the hour of death uncertain; as in that case, they would not have been so solicitous with regard to its arrival. But S. Austin, S. Gregory, and other saints assure us, on the contrary, that it is a very great mercy of God to keep us in this ignorance, that we may always be prepared for it. For, if we knew the precise period, this assurance would give occasion of living more unguardedly, and of sinning more freely. If, with this uncertainty of the hour of our death, we live notwithstanding, so very remissly; what should we do, were we assured that we were not to die for some years? SS. Gregory, Austin, and Bonaventure say, that God chose to leave us in this uncertainty, purposely to prevent all attachment to temporal things; that, seeing every hour, nay every moment, we may lose them, we may not be tied to them, but aspire to those we shall always possess, when once we have obtained them. Fool, says the Son of God to the rich covetous man, (Luke xii. 20.) this night thy soul shall be required of thee, and what then will become of all these riches thou hast amassed. S. Bonaventure.

Ver. 35. At even, at midnight, or at the cock-crowing, or in the morning. These are generally referred to the different ages of man's life; infancy, youth, manhood, and old age. we are exhorted to be always in readiness, for we know not at what hour the Judge will come. Nic. de Lyra. — We are taught to watch, because we are charged with the care of our soul, which is the temple or house of God, and which is to be his temple for all eternity. V.

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MARK 14

CHAPTER XIV.

Ver. 1. Though the evangelists generally use the words pasch and azymes promiscuously, yet S. Mark distinguishes them, being really different. The pasch is used for the 14th day of the moon of the first month. But the 15th day, on which they departed out of Egypt, was the feast of the azymes, or the unleavened bread; which continued seven days, till the 21st day of the moon inclusive. Ven. Bede. — Pasch is also used for the sabbath day within the seven days of the solemnity; (Jo. xix. 14.) and also for all the sacrifices made during the seven days of the feast.

Ver. 2. They were not so much afraid of the sedition itself, as of the people delivering Christ out of their hands. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 3. Of precious[1] spikenard. This was a perfume extracted and distilled from the leaves, tops, or stalks, of the plant or herb called nard. It was the custom of the eastern people to pour such precious perfumes on their own heads, or on the heads of their guests whom they had a mind to honour. Wi. —

This happened six days previous to the pasch. The woman here mentioned was Mary, sister of Lazarus. John xii. 3.

Ver. 4. It was chiefly Judas Iscariot that murmured here. S. John only mentions him; perhaps some others had been excited to complain, by the traitor. This is certain, that if any concurred in murmuring with Judas, they afterwards repented, on hearing the answer given immediately by our Saviour. D. Dionys.

Ver. 7. Christ here answers the apostles, by informing them that he should not always be with them, but would shortly leave them, as to his corporal presence, though he spiritually will remain with them, and their successors, to the end of time. Mat. xxviii. — Behold I am, &c. He will not always be with them, so as to want their services. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 10. Many of the present day shudder at the thought of the horrid and inexpressible crime of Judas, in betraying his Master, his Lord, and his God, and yet do not take care to avoid the like wickedness themselves; for, as often as for a little gain they neglect the duties of faith and charity, they become traitors to God, who is charity and faith. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 12. Whither wilt thou, &c. By these words the disciples teach us to direct our every step according to the will of God; therefore does their Lord tell them, with whom he would eat the pasch, to go two of them into the city. S. Jerom.

Ver. 14. Where is my refectory:[2] where I may eat the pasch, or the paschal supper of the lamb sacrificed? Lit. in the Lat. where is my eating, or my refectory? but it is generally agreed that here is meant a place to eat in. Wi.

This is my Body.

Ver. 22. This which I now give, and which you now receive; for the bread is not the figure only of Christ, but is changed into the true body of Christ; and he himself says, The bread, which I will give you, is my flesh. S. John vi. But the flesh of Christ is not seen, on account of our infirmity; for if we were allowed to see with our eyes the flesh and blood of Jesus, we should not dare to approach the blessed sacrament. Our Lord therefore condescending to our weakness, preserves the outward species of bread and wine, but changes the bread and wine into the reality of flesh and blood. Theophy. — S. Chrysostom, in his thirtieth sermon on the treason of Judas, says: "Christ is also now present to adorn our table, (altar) the same that was present to adorn that table. For it is not man that causes the elements to become the body and blood of Christ, but the very Christ, the same that was crucified for us: oude gar anthropos estin o koion ta prokeimena ginesthai soma kai aima christou all autos o staurotheis uper emon christos. The priest stands his vicegerent, and pronounces the words, but the power and grace is of God. He says, this is my body, and the word changes the elements: and as the sentence 'increase and multiply, and fill the earth, was spoken once, but still imparts fecundity to human nature throughout all time: so these words (of consecration) once spoken, constitute an absolute, perfect sacrifice upon every altar of the Church from that day to this, yea even to the time when Christ shall come again at the last day." Schema pleron esteken o iereus, ta remata phtheggomenos ekeina e de dunamis, kai e charis tou theou esti. touto mou esti to soma, phesi touto to rema metarruthmizei ta prokeimena. Kai kathaper e phone ekeine e legousa "auxanesthe, kai plethunesthe, kai plerosate ten gen,"

errethe men apax, dia pantos de tou chronou ginetai ergo endunamousa ten phusin ten emeteran pros paidopoiian. outo kai e phone aute apax lechtheisa, kath ekasten trapezan en tais ekklesiiais, ex ekeinou mechri semeron, kai mechri tes autou parousias, ten thusian apertismenen ergasetai. S.

Chrysostom, Serm. xxx, on the treachery of Judas.

These words are so plain, that it is difficult to imagine others more explicit.

Their force and import will however appear in a still stronger light, if we consider the formal promise Christ had made to his apostles, as related by S.

John, that he would give them his flesh to eat, that same flesh he was to deliver up for the life of the world. He on that occasion confirmed with remarkable emphasis of expression the reality of this manducation, assuring them that his flesh was meat indeed, and his blood drink indeed; and when some of the disciples were shocked at such a proposal, he still insisted that unless they eat his flesh, they should have no life in them. The possibility of it he evinced from his divine power, to be exemplified in his miraculous ascension; the necessity of it he established, by permitting those to abandon him who refused to believe it; and the belief of it he enforced on the minds of his disciples, from the consideration that he, their teacher, was the Son of God, and the author of their eternal salvation. The apostles were deeply impressed with these thoughts, previously to the institution of the holy Eucharist; consequently when they beheld Jesus Christ, just before his death, taking bread into his sacred hands; when after blessing it with solemnity, they heard him say, Take, eat; this is my body, which shall be given for you; they must necessarily have concluded, that it was truly his body, which he now gave them to eat, according to his former promise. And though their reason or senses might have started difficulties, yet all these were obviated by their belief of his being God, and consequently able to effect whatever he pleased, and to make good whatever he said. — Moreover, if we consult tradition, we shall find that the Greek, as well as the Latin Church, has uniformly declared in favour of the literal sense of Christ's words, as may be seen at large in all Catholic controvertists. The learned author of the *Perpetuité de la Foi*, and his continuator, Renaudot, in the two additional quarto volumes, have invincibly demonstrated, that the belief of all the Oriental Christians perfectly coincides with that of the Catholic

Church, respecting the real presence. Dr. Philip Nicolai, though a Protestant, candidly acknowledges, in his first book of the Kingdom of Christ, p. 22, "that not only the churches of the Greeks, but also the Russians, the Georgians, the Armenians, the Judæans, and the Ethiopians, as many of them as believe in Christ, hold the true and real presence of the body and blood of our Lord." This general agreement amongst the many Churches of the Christian world, affords the strongest evidence against Secker and others, who pretend that the doctrine of the real presence is a mere innovation; which was not started till 700 years after Christ's death. For, how will their supposition accord with the belief of the Nestorians and Eutychians, who were separated from the Church of Rome long before that period, and who were found to agree exactly with Catholics concerning this important tenent? — See this point clearly given in Rutter's Evangelical Harmony.

This is my Blood.

Ver. 24. Which shall be shed. With words so explicit, with the unanimous agreement of the Eastern and Western Churches, how can any Dissenters bring themselves to believe that there is nothing more designed, or given, than a memorial of Christ's passion and death? Catholics, who believe in the real presence, do certainly renew in themselves the remembrance of our Saviour's death and passion, with more lively sentiments of devotion than they who believe it to be mere bread and wine. The outward forms of bread and wine, which remain in the Eucharist, are chiefly designed to signify or represent to us three things; viz. 1. The passion of Christ, of which they are the remembrance; 2. the body and blood of Christ, really, though sacramentally present, of which they are the veil; and 3. everlasting life, of which they are the pledge. — N. B. In speaking of the real presence in the Eucharist, Catholics hold that Christ is corporally and substantially present, but not carnally; i.e.

not in that gross, natural, and sensible manner, in which our separated brethren so frequently misrepresent our doctrine.

Ver. 25. This vine represents the Synagogue, according to Isaias. The vine, or vineyard of the Lord of hosts is the house of Israel. Of this vine Christ drank for some time; and though many of the branches were become useless, there were yet many that still brought forth fruit. But Christ now going to his passion, declares that it would be no longer acceptable to him, since the figures were not to pass into reality. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 26. Jesus Christ is seized upon Mount Olivet, whence he ascended into heaven; that we might know that the place on earth where we watch and pray, where we suffer chains without resistance, is the place whence we are to ascend into heaven. S. Jerom.

Ver. 27. Christ permitted his disciples to fall, that they might learn not to trust in themselves. To strengthen his prediction, he adduces the

testimony of Zacharias the prophet, (xiii. 7.) I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep shall be dispersed. Theophy. . . . This text is expressed in other words, being there spoken in the person of the prophet: Strike the pastor, and the sheep shall be dispersed. Ven. Bede. — By these words, the prophet prays for the passion of the Lord. The Almighty Father answers his prayer: I will strike the shepherd.

The Son is sent by the Father, and is stricken by becoming incarnate and suffering death. S. Jerom.

Ver. 37. You who were ready to die for me, cannot watch with me! We are here taught a great duty of a Christian life, and that is, to beg of God, that he would give us strength to observe and follow the motions and inspirations of his Holy Spirit, and never to resist the calls of heaven.

Ver. 45. Our Lord received the kiss of the traitor, that he might not appear to avoid being delivered up; and at the same time he fulfilled that of the Psalmist, with those who hated peace, I was peaceful. Ps. cxix. 7.

Ver. 46. Here is Joseph betrayed and sold by his brethren, and pierced in his soul with a sword. S. Jerom.

Ver. 47. This was Peter, as we learn from S. John xviii. 10. He is here actuated with his usual ardent zeal, calling to mind the example of Phinees, who by executing justice on the wicked, merited the reward of justice, and a continual priesthood. Ven. Bede. — S. Mark conceals his master's name, lest he should seem to be publishing the ardour of his zeal for Christ. Theophy.

Ver. 51. This probably was the owner, or the son of the owner of the garden, who hearing the tumult came to see what was the cause. It must have been a young man from the Greek word neaniskos. T.

Ver. 55. Though the law prescribed there should be only one high priest, yet at this time there were many, being appointed yearly by the Roman governor; and those are here called chief priests who had once

been invested with the dignity of high priest, but were at that time out of office. Theophy.

Ver. 56. Their evidence did not agree. Others translate, their testimonies were not sufficient; that is, so as to amount to a crime that made him guilty of death.

The Greek, as well as the Latin text, may be taken in either sense. The high priest, vexed at this, stood up, and asked him questions, hoping to make him appear guilty by his own confession. Wi. — This latter sense is given to the same expression, v. 59. *infra*.

Ver. 57. Thus has iniquity lied to itself, (Ps. xxvi.) as formerly in the case of the wife of Putiphar against Joseph, (Gen. xxix.) and the elders against Susanna.

Dan. S. Jerom.

Ver. 61. Our Redeemer was silent, because he knew they would not attend to his words; therefore does he say in S. Luke, If I shall tell you, you will not believe me. Theophy.

Ver. 63. Caiphas, in order to excite their hatred against what was said, rent his garments, and thus deprived himself of the priestly dignity, by transgressing the precept; which, speaking of the high priest says: He shall not uncover his head, and his garments he shall not rend. Lev. xxi. 10. S. Leo the Great. — By the high priest rending his garments he shews, that the Jewish priesthood, on account of their crimes, was now dissolved; whereas the tunic of Christ, by which the one true Catholic Church is prefigured, was seamless, and not to be divided. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 71. In this one apostle, Peter, the first and chief in the order of apostles, in whom the Church was figured, both sorts were to be signified, viz. the strong and the weak, because the Church is not without both. S. Austin, Serm. xiii. de verb. Do. — Again, our Saviour would shew by the example of the chief apostle, that no man ought to presume of himself, when even S. Peter was not secure and immoveable. Idem. tract. lxvi. in Evan. Joan. and S. Leo. serm. ix.

de Pass. Do.

[1] V. 3. Unguenti nardi spicati pretiosi, murou nardou pistikes polutelous.

Both here in S. Mark, and also in S. John, C. xii. 3. we read pistikes, which by the Greek agees with nard, and not with ointment. The interpreters are much divided about the signification of the word pistikes: some late writers would needs have pistides to come from pio or pino, and to signify liquid, but this does not seem well grounded. Others, with S. Aug. would have pistikes to be taken from the name of some country or place from whence this precious nard was brought. The most common opinion seems that of S. Hierom, with whom agree Theophylactus, and Euthymius, that pistika, derived from pistis, signifies true and genuine nard, and so of the greatest price and value.

[2] V. 14. Ubi est refectio mea, ubi pascha manducem? Pou esti to kataluma, opou pascha . . . phago.

[3] V. 56. Convenientia testimonia non erant. isai ai marturiai ouk esan. The word isai may either signify that they did not agree together, or that they were not sufficient to get him condemned, which latter is the opinion of Erasmus, who translates, non erant idonea.

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MARK 15

CHAPTER XV.

Ver. 1. It was customary with the Jews to bind and deliver over to the Roman governors those whom they had condemned in their own councils; but we must not suppose that this was the first time they bound Jesus; for, as S. John informs us, when first they apprehended him, they put manacles upon him.

Ven. Bede.

Ver. 2. It may be remarked upon this answer of our Lord, that he was not unwilling to answer the questions put to him by the governor, who condemned him contrary to his inclination, though he would not condescend to return an answer to the question of the high priests, as they were not worthy of the favour. Theophy.

Ver. 6. This practice of releasing to the people any prisoner they might think proper, was instituted in order to captivate the will of the people; which was most commonly done on the festival day, when the Jews were assembled from the different provinces to Jerusalem. But that the blindness and malice of this people might be more apparent, the evangelist here describes the atrocious wickedness of the man they preferred to the Son of God. Gloss.

Ver. 10. Since envy put to death the Author of life, Jesus Christ, how watchful should all Christians be against every degree of that sin. S. Chrysos. hom. xl.

in Matt.

Ver. 21. S. Jerom thinks Alexander and Rufus were disciples of Christ, and on this account the name of their father is here expressed. S. Jerom. in D. Diony.

Ver. 23. S. Matt. says mixed with gall; for gall is here used for bitterness, and wine that has myrrh in it is a very strong bitter; although, perhaps, both gall and myrrh might have been ingredients to increase the bitterness. S. Austin. —

Or, in the confusion that was occasioned, some might have offered him one thing, some another; one person giving vinegar and gall, another wine mixed with myrrh. Theophy. — Wine mingled with myrrh may perhaps be used for vinegar. S. Jer. — This was given to criminals, to lessen their torments. Our Lord was pleased to taste the bitterness, but he would not permit the relief which the admittance of the same into his stomach might have afforded. Thus also were the scriptures fulfilled: they gave me gall for my food, and in my thirst they gave me vinegar to drink. Ps. lxxviii. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 25. S. Mark is the only evangelist who says it was the third hour. S. John says it was the sixth. But these may easily be reconciled by supposing that he was crucified towards the end of the third hour, that is, about eleven of the clock, or half-past eleven, which being near the sixth hour, or twelve, the evangelist might say it was the sixth hour. Nic. de Lyra. — The third hour. The ancient account divided the day into four parts, which were named from the hour from which they began: the first, third, sixth, and ninth hour. Our Lord was crucified a little before noon; before the third hour had quite expired; but when the sixth hour was near at hand. Ch.

Ver. 26. It was written on a board, or rather on parchment fixed to a board, (as Leipsius informs us) expressing the cause why he was crucified, viz. because he was the King of the Jews. And, indeed, Pilate himself was fully persuaded that he was the Messiah promised to the

Jews: and though he knew him to be innocent, he connived the more at his death through fear lest he might attempt something against the Roman empire, if he were permitted to continue. At the same time, by putting up his cause, he wished to revenge himself of the Jews, for their importunity and obstinacy in compelling him, partly against his will, to condemn him to death. For what could be more ignominious to the Jews than to see their king crucified at their own request, and for no other reason than because he was their king, and they did not wish him to reign over them. Thus did they receive the king for whose coming they had so long sighed, and from whom they had expected delivery from the Roman yoke, and the subjugation of the whole world to their own power. Sirinus.

Ver. 28. This text of Isaias regards the Messias according to the very letter. V.

Ver. 32. Afterwards they saw Him arising out of the sepulchre whom they thought unable to descend from the cross. Where, O Jew, is thy infidelity? I ask you yourselves. You shall be your own judges. How much more astonishing is it to be able, when dead, to rise again, than, when living, to descend from the cross? You desired a small exertion of power, and a much greater is here performed: but still your infidelity would not be cured. All have turned out of the way, all have become useless. S. Jer. — If the Scribes and Pharisees did not believe in Christ when he rose from the dead, neither would they have believed in him had he left the cross. Though the scripture had foretold in many places that he was to suffer, Ps. xxi. They have dug my hands and feet; and Ps. xcv, They shall look upon him whom they have pierced; He shall reign from the tree: (and which St. Justin assures us the Jews had erased from the psalm) yet where can the Jews point out that it was foretold he should descend from the cross? Tir.

Ver. 39. The centurion considered the crying out of our Saviour as an effect not of human, but divine power, since it generally happens that people at the moment the soul quits the body are reduced to so debilitated a state, that they are scarce able to utter the least word. Although Jesus was truly the natural, not the adoptive, Son of God, it is

nevertheless probable that the centurion, being a Gentile, did not speak in this manner as if he knew Jesus to be the natural Son of God. He did not know that the Son of God was really true God, equal to the Father, but called him Son of God, as if adopted, on account of his extraordinary sanctity; or, perhaps, he might have called him the Son of God, in order to oppose the Jews, who called our Saviour a blasphemer, because he made himself the Son of God. D. Diony.

Ver. 42. Ven. Bede thinks the word parasceve is derived from the Greek paraskeue, signifying a preparation. It was the day before the sabbath, on which the Jews were accustomed to prepare two meals, one for the parasceve, and another for the sabbath; the Jews not being allowed to dress any meat on the latter day, on account of its great solemnity. The Jews learnt this word of the Greeks, who lived among them in Jerusalem. Ven. Bede.

Ver. 43. A noble Decurion. The Decurions among the Romans were first called so as having ten men under them, as the centurions were over a hundred. But some of the Decurions were also Counsellors in towns, as is here signified by the Greek word Bouleutes. Wi.

Ver. 46. According to the description of those that have seen it, it is a kind of small chamber, the height of which, from top to bottom, is eight feet and an inch, its length six feet and one inch, and its breadth fifteen feet ten inches. Its entrance, or vestibule, which looks towards the east, is but four feet high, and two feet four inches wide. The place within, where our Lord's body was laid, takes up a whole side of the cave. The stone which was laid to secure the door of the sepulchre is still remaining, and according to Mr. Maundrell, is two yards and a quarter long, one broad, and one thick: but the particular parts of it are not visible, being all incrustated over with white marble, except in five or six little places, where it is left bare to receive the kisses and other devotions of pilgrims. Mark Luke's Voyage to Asia Minor, Vol. II. p. 12. and Maundrell's Journey from Aleppo to Jerusalem.

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MARK 16

CHAPTER XVI.

Ver. 1. Saturday evening, after the sun was set, for the sabbath began and ended with the setting sun.

Ver. 2. S. Mark says very early, the sun being now risen, whereas S. John tells us that it was yet dark. But when S. Mark says the sun was risen, he means that it began, by its approach to the horizon, to enlighten the heavens, at which time there is still darkness remaining, (according to S. John) which decreases as light approaches the earth. S. Austin.

Ver. 5. S. Matthew says the angel was sitting on the stone, whilst S. Mark says that they saw him sitting on the right side of the sepulchre. This must not surprise us; for the angel which first appeared sitting upon the stone, might have been afterwards seen by him sitting on the right side of the sepulchre.

Theophy. — Perhaps the angel mentioned by S. Matthew is different from the one mentioned by S. Mark. Or it may be understood, that the women entering the monument, which may mean the enclosure of it, saw the angel sitting on the stone, which was placed on the right side of the sepulchre. S. Austin.

Ver. 9. This appearance of our Saviour is more fully related by S. John. Our Lord arose early from the monument in which he had been placed late in the evening, thus fulfilling the words of the psalmist: In the evening weeping shall have place, and in the morning gladness. Ps. xxix. **Ven. Bede.** — Rising early. It appears from this that our Saviour arose early, about sunrise, as was the sentiment of S. Austin; though S. Gregory seems to think that he arose at midnight, in the same manner as Samson, who was a figure of Christ, arose in the middle of the night and carried away the gates of Gaza. If we follow this opinion, we must understand the word early as referring to the verb appeared, not to the participle rising, and then the sentence will be: he rising, (having arisen) appeared early the first day of the week. The first

interpretation, however, of S. Austin seems more agreeable to the text: he rising early the first day of the week, appeared, &c.

Ver. 12. He had appeared to Magdalene in the form of a gardener, and to two disciples in the form of a traveller.

Ver. 14. At length, &c. in the Latin text, taken according to the letter, is lastly, or last of all: but if we examine and compare the four gospels, this was not the last time that Christ appeared to his disciples after his resurrection. We can only then understand it of the last time mentioned by this evangelist. — To the eleven. If this apparition (as it was the opinion of S. Augustine) was made when S. Thomas was not with them, they were only then ten, without S.

Thomas and Judas. The evangelist here calls them eleven, because the apostolical college (Judas being dead) consisted of no more than eleven. And this way of speaking may be justified by diverse examples: one instance may suffice. A meeting of the Jewish sanhedrim might be called the Council of the Seventy-two, though it many times happened that all the seventy-two were not there present. Wi. — Some think that this was the last apparition of Jesus Christ, after which he quitted the earth, and ascended into heaven. V.

Ver. 16. Let those weep and lament who have not yet seen him, and in a short time they shall receive consolation. Blessed are they that weep, for they shall be comforted, S. Mat. v. S. Jerom. — Perhaps some one will say within himself, I have already believed, I shall be saved: he says true, if his faith be supported by good works; for that only is true faith, which does not contradict in works what is believed in words. S. Greg.

Ver. 19. By these words it is not to be understood that Jesus is to be confined to that particular posture of body, or that the Father has any hands, or any human shape; for God is a pure, incorporeal, and all-perfect Spirit. The image of God, as he is in himself, comes not within the reach of our mortal senses.

When the Scripture, therefore, speaks of God, it uses such imagery of language as is adapted to our senses, that it may thereby convey to us

some imperfect knowledge of those sublime mysteries, which are ineffable in themselves, and incomprehensible to our understanding. Thus we are informed that Jesus Christ sits at the right hand of God, the Father Almighty, to signify that, as man, our Lord is raised to the height of glory, and to that supreme beatitude, than which there is nothing higher, and nothing greater in the whole bliss of heaven; and that he moreover holds the same sovereign dominion with the Father over all creatures; because, as God, he is equal to the Father in power, in wisdom, and in all perfection. See Pouget, p. 256. ed. in fol. — On the right hand of God. Jesus Christ, our Redeemer, was not man only, but truly God, the same God with his eternal Father: and hereby is signified that the person, who took upon him human nature, and became man, is equal in dignity with the Father: he, who, as man, ascended into heaven.

[2]When S. Jerom says that most Greek copies wanted this chapter, he speaks not of chapters according to our present division, but only of the last 12

verses, which formerly made what was called a little chapter: yet these twelve verses must have been omitted in those MSS. by some negligent transcribers.

Now they are found in all, both Latin and Greek copies. They are found in the Canons of Eusebius on the Gospels; in S. Jerom in several places; in S. Amb.

l. iii, in Luc. tom. iii, p. 292. Ed. Paris, an. 1582, in S. Aug. l. iii, de consensu Evang. c. xxv, tom. 3, part 2, p. 142, &c. Wi. — S. Gregory of Nyssa, (orat. 2. de Resurr.) says, that the best copies of S. Mark's gospel finished with the 8th verse, a trembling and fear had seized them: Εν τοις ακριβεστέροις τοις Κεφαλαίοις του Ευαγγελίου του Μάρκου η γραφή η τελειή ην εν τω οκτώτω, εχει το τέλος. It is the very generally received sentiment of the learned, that the last 12 verses were given by S. Mark; and the most probable reason yet offered for the omission of them in various copies is, that the transcribers followed a mutilated copy, where the last page was wanting. V.

Ver. 20. Let us here take notice, that, as the apostles confirmed their words by the signs that followed, so also in us must our words be confirmed by works.

"Grant, O Jesus! that the discourse we deliver, concerning virtue, may be confirmed by works and actions; that thus, by thy co-operation, we may become perfect in word and work; for to Thee is due the glory of our discourses and actions." Theophylactus.

[1] V. 14. Novissimè, usteron, posterius.

**[2] V. 19. S. Hieron. Ep. ad Hebidiā, q. 3, tom. 4, part 1, p. 172:
omnibus Græcis Libris penè hoc capitulum non habentibus.**